A gateway to Afghanistan and Central Asia for India, political differences between Iran and India on Afghanistan are not emphasised in popular discourse. On the ground, however, these differences have a life and dynamism of their own, and not all of them had to do with the US-Iran rivalry. To begin with, having played a critical role in keeping the partisans thriving in India during the 1990s, Iran's strategic calculus in wake of the US military intervention put Tehran and New Delhi in an awkward situation. India was supporting the US-led NATO intervention and saw it as an opportunity to reengage with Afghanistan, but Iran, after initial tactical convergence with Washington at the 2001 Bonn Conference, grew increasingly averse to the US military presence in its neighbourhood. India's vote against Iran's nuclear programme at the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) in November 2009 created tremendous tension between the two countries. Moreover, New Delhi's deepening ties with Israel and Saudi Arabia underlined Iran's marginalisation in the Indian strategic calculus (this began changing after the US-Iran nuclear deal, and the signing of the deal that gave India rights to develop the Chabahar port). Though diplomatic attempts were made to bridge this gap given India's trade and energy links with Iran, political differences persisted. Within Afghanistan, for instance, Iranian intelligence agencies began developing links with and financially supporting factions of the Afghan Taliban and other anti-US factions regardless of their Sunni orientation.[121] It was a big loss for India's partisans who needed Iran's logistical and political support to see their anti-Taliban and anti-Pakistan advocacy bear fruit. A closer examination of Iran's approach towards Afghanistan shows that it was very similar to that of Pakistan, but focused more in west Afghanistan as opposed to Pakistan's dominance in the south and east. Undermining Iran's popular image as a constructive partner of India in Afghanistan, many Afghans found Tehran's foreign policy highly interventionist.[122]

Like Pakistan, Iran also cultivated its own proxy groups to influence Afghan politics. Former governor of Herat, Daud Saba, considers this strategy 'crazy' and wanted Iran to treat Afghanistan as an independent country. 'We are land-locked country [and] we have certain rights recognised by the international community i.e. [access to] ports [and] transit routes. And what we have seen in the past years [is that] there were breaches of these international laws by both our neighbours—